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# B

## Baal

### t285: Baal

Baal was the most important male god that the Canaanite people worshiped before the Israelites conquered Canaan, the land God had promised them. People sometimes used the name “Baal” to talk about one specific god in one place. At other times, people used the word that meant “many Baals” to refer to all the male false gods in Canaan.

In the original language, the name Baal literally means a lord, master, or husband—someone who controls or has authority over someone or something. The Canaanites believed that Baal controlled the wind and rain, caused plants to grow, and also gave people children. So people made sacrifices of animals and grain to Baal, and sometimes also had sexual relations with each other as part of their worship of Baal.

Asherah was a false goddess whom the Canaanites also worshiped. Asherah was one of Baal’s partners, and people often talked about and worshiped Baal and Asherah together. As part of their worship of Asherah, people often made a wooden pole, sometimes carved images on it, and set it upright in the ground to honor Asherah.

## Baal

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (1046397 KB)

## baptism

To **baptize** someone, or something, means to immerse it in water to wash it. It comes from the Greek word “baptizo.”

The word has a special religious meaning. In the Old Testament, [Jewish priests](#) would baptize themselves before they would do their work in the [temple](#) of God. This made them “[clean](#)” so that they were fit to approach God.

When people who were not Jewish wanted to follow God, they could be baptized. After that, they would be accepted as part of God’s people. We do not hear about this custom in the Old Testament, but we know about it from other books from the history of the Jews.

When [John the baptizer](#) came, he did something new by telling all the people that they should take baptism. Being born as a Jew wasn’t enough to be part of God’s

people! All people needed to [repent](#), to say sorry for the bad things that they had done. They needed to turn away from their old life, and to start a new way of living. They should start obeying God!

Just before Jesus went back to [heaven](#), he told his [disciples](#) to go and tell people everywhere that Jesus has all [authority](#). Jesus told them to make all people Jesus’s disciples, and to baptize them in the name of the father, the son, and the [Holy Spirit](#).

And so, from that time onwards, we see that as soon as people began to [believe](#) in Jesus they took baptism. This baptism was a sign of their repentance and need for [forgiveness](#). But it was also a sign that they now belonged to Jesus and wanted to follow him.

Paul, in his letters, explains that when we take baptism it is as if we die and become alive again. We die by going under in the water, and become alive again by coming up out of the water. This is a symbol showing that our old life is dead. We now have a new life because we belong to Jesus. Jesus died for us, and became alive again. When we take baptism, we accept that Jesus died in our place, and that we are new people because God has forgiven us. Just as water cleanses our bodies from dirt, Jesus has “cleansed” us from our [sins](#). Now we are fit to approach God!

The ritual of baptism was something that only needed to be done once.

### When you are translating baptism, be careful about the following things:

The word baptism, and to baptize someone, can be difficult to translate. Many people use a word that sounds like the [Greek](#) word “baptizo.” New [believers](#) will have to slowly learn what this word means. You can also use a term that would be more meaningful for the people in your language group. If people in your community have a form of ritual bathing, this word might be helpful in translating baptism. However, be sure you understand the meaning of the ritual in your community, and think about the difference between the meaning of that ritual and baptism in the Bible. You may need to explain how baptism in the Bible is different from the ritual in your community.

You can also use a word that sounds like “baptizo,” but then add a small phrase to give more explanation about its meaning.

## baptism

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (2444325 KB)

## basket

People use a **basket** to carry or store things. People make baskets by weaving together thin sticks, stems of plants, or reeds. A reed is a plant that grows in the water.

Some baskets were small and people carried them on their back. People used these baskets for carrying food. Other baskets were bigger, and two people might be needed to carry them when they were full. For example, fishermen used these baskets to collect the fish that they caught and to take it to the market.

## basket

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (420380 KB)

## belief

**To believe** and to have **faith** mean the same thing.

If you believe in someone, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do.

**Abraham** believed that God spoke the truth when he promised that Abraham would have many **descendants**, even though Abraham was already old and did not have even one child. Abraham trusted that God would fulfill his promise, even though it seemed impossible.

If you believe in God, you accept that God exists and that what God says in the Bible is true. You trust that God will fulfill all his promises, even when it seems impossible. As a result, you are committed to obey everything that God wants you to do.

When you believe in Jesus, you believe that Jesus is indeed the **son of God**. You trust that Jesus has indeed died for your **sins**, and that God has **forgiven** and accepted you. As a result, you are committed to do everything that Jesus has commanded.

The Bible sometimes says that people should “believe in Jesus’s name.” This means the same thing as to believe in Jesus.

Someone who has great faith or belief, trusts God-or Jesus-very much.

**When you are translating the word “believe,” be careful about the following things:**

In some languages, the word “believe” can sound as if someone only hopes that something is true, but they are not sure. This is not the right meaning. Therefore,

sometimes it can be better to use a word that means “trust.” Pause here and do the following activity as a group: Ask one person to volunteer to be the person who has to trust, or have faith. That person should stand with their back to a group of at least 5 people, if you have that many people. Those five people should stand right behind the volunteer. They should be capable and willing to catch the volunteer. Ask the volunteer to fall back into the arms of the group of people. Ask the volunteer: Did you hesitate to do that? How do you feel as you decide whether or not to fall back into the arms of the group?

Maybe the volunteer chooses to not actually fall back, even though the volunteer knows that the volunteer’s friends will catch them. Ask the group: How does the group feel when the volunteer chooses to not fall back into their arms?

Maybe the volunteer chooses to fall back into the group’s arms. How does the volunteer feel after the group catches him? How does the group feel, knowing that the person has trusted them? This is an example of having faith, or trusting. You do not trust unless you really fall back into the arms of the group. You may say that you trust them, but true trust does not happen until you fall. Trusting means to act on what you say.

## belief

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (2346908 KB)

## believer

After Pentecost, the people who followed Jesus were also called **believers**. A believer is a person who has chosen to believe the **good news** about Jesus and to trust in Jesus and follow him as their **Lord**, or master. In Acts, people often call this group of people “brothers,” or “brothers and sisters,” because believers are like members of the same family with God as their father. Some Bible translations translate “brothers” as “believers.”

## believer

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (395996 KB)

## Bethlehem

**Bethlehem** is the birthplace of Jesus.

Bethlehem was a small village in **Israel**. The name Bethlehem means “house of bread.” In the Old Testament, the events in the book of Ruth took place in Bethlehem. Ruth was a Moabite woman, so she was

not an [Israelite](#). Ruth's first husband had died, so Ruth came to live in Bethlehem with her Israelite mother-in-law. Later, Ruth married an Israelite man from Bethlehem. The great grandson of Ruth and her Israelite husband was [David](#), who would later become the most beloved king of Israel.

Because king David was born in Bethlehem, Bethlehem is also called the city of David.

God later said through the [prophet](#) Micah that another very important ruler would be born in Bethlehem. Therefore the [Jews](#) were expecting that the [Messiah](#), the special King and [Savior](#) that God had promised to send, would be born in Bethlehem.

God fulfilled this promise when Jesus was born in Bethlehem.

Bethlehem was a few kilometers away from [Jerusalem](#), which was the most important city for the Jews.

## Bethlehem

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (928484 KB)

## Bethsaida

**Bethsaida** is a village in the province of [Galilee](#). It was probably close to the city of [Capernaum](#), because [John](#) tells us that Jesus's [disciples](#) Andrew and Peter came from Bethsaida, but Mark tells us that they lived in Capernaum. The village was close to the [Sea of Galilee](#), and many people in the village made their living from fishing. The name Bethsaida even means "house of fishing."

## Bethsaida

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (362900 KB)

## blasphemy

To **blaspheme** someone means to speak [evil](#) about a person, and to insult someone. A person who [curses](#) God, insults God, dishonors God, or makes God seem less powerful or important, is blaspheming God. The punishment for blasphemy was death.

## blasphemy

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (270620 KB)

## bless

When God **blesses** a person, God is doing, or promising to do, something good for that person.

When a human speaks a **blessing** over another person, they are [praying](#) that God will do good things for this other person.

When people are blessing God, it means they are [worshipping](#) God and thanking him for his goodness and his blessings.

When people are blessing something-for instance food-this means that they are thanking God for it.

When you call someone **blessed**, you mean to say that other people can congratulate that person. Other people can be glad for those people, because God has blessed them.

The opposite of a blessing is a [curse](#). Through Moses, God told the [Israelites](#) that if they would obey God's commandments, God would bless them. But if they would disobey God, God would curse them. God will not protect those people who are cursed, and people who are cursed will not be in a good [relationship](#) with God.

## bless

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (890924 KB)

## blood

Every human and animal lives because God puts his own life breath in it. In the Old Testament, blood symbolizes this life breath. A person cannot live without blood, and so when blood drains out of a body, it is as if God's life breath is leaving the body.

In the Old Testament, God told the people that they should not eat the blood of an animal. When they ate meat, they first had to completely drain the animal of blood. By draining the blood from the animal, it was as if the people gave the life breath of the animal back to God.

Because blood, as long as it is in our bodies, represented life, losing blood represented death. Anything which is dead symbolizes how bad [sin](#) has made God's good creation. Therefore, a dead body of a human or an animal was [unclean](#), meaning unacceptable before God, and anyone who touched such a dead body would become unclean as well.

A person who was losing blood was for this reason also unclean. Even though the person was not dead, it was as if they-symbolically-were already a little bit dead.

Therefore even a woman who was just menstruating, or a man who was discharging blood, was unclean until the bleeding was over. Anyone who touched such a person became unclean as well. In the [Gospels](#) we see a bleeding woman touching Jesus-but instead of this making Jesus unclean, Jesus made the woman clean by healing her from her sickness!

Because blood is so important for a person's life, the word is often used as picture language for "life." So, someone who killed someone has "shed blood," even if no blood has flowed.

Even though losing blood was bad and made someone unclean, blood of animals that were sacrificed to God were used to make people or things clean. Blood was an important part of the [sacrifices](#) that the [Israelites](#) made to God. When the [priests](#) brought God a sacrifice, they collected the blood of the animal that they were sacrificing. Depending on the type of ritual, the priests would sprinkle the blood on the [altar](#), or on some specific object, or on a person. This symbolized that these objects or people were now clean. They were now suitable for serving God.

Blood was also used to make a formal agreement, called a [covenant](#). When God made his covenant with [Abraham](#), Abraham had to kill some animals, and therefore he shed blood. Jesus says that his, Jesus', blood is the sign of the new covenant. This means that the death of Jesus made possible a new covenant between God and people. In the Old Testament, the blood of animals made people clean. But now the blood of Jesus makes the people who [believe](#) in him clean-God [forgives](#) them and accepts them. In the Old Testament, people had to sacrifice animals again and again. But Jesus died once, and this was sufficient for all the generations of the people!

## blood

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (2434868 KB)

## boat

People build **boats** to travel across water. A boat can be very small and hold just a few people, or it can be large and hold hundreds of people. A boat can be open to the top, or it can have a roof over a part of the boat with one or several rooms inside.

People can move a boat forward by moving long sticks called oars through the water. This is called rowing. Larger boats would also have sails. A sail is a large piece of cloth that is attached to a long pole called a mast. The sail will catch the wind, and this moves

the boat forward. Sailors are people who handle the boat and maneuver the sails so that the wind gives them the best speed. In the Old Testament, Jonah got on a sailboat like this when he was not willing to go to Nineveh.

Jesus and his [disciples](#) often traveled by boat across the [Sea of Galilee](#). These were boats used by fishermen to go across the lake and to catch fish in the lake. These were rowing boats, though some boats may have had a small sail as well. These boats were just the right size to fit Jesus and his 12 disciples.

In the book of Acts, we read that Paul also traveled by boat sometimes. These boats were larger, and had sails. People traveled in these boats for longer distances. Sometimes storms made traveling by boat difficult, and a shipwreck could occur-this means that the boat would break and would sink. People could die in shipwrecks. Traveling by boat could therefore be quite dangerous.

A boat has a small, movable, piece of wood attached to it which is called a rudder. This allows the people to make the boat go in the direction that they want. [James](#) in his epistle compares our tongue to a rudder of a boat-very small, but very powerful!

You can look in the video dictionary for some pictures of different types of boats.

To help your teams understand the size of the boat that Jesus and his disciples used, try drawing in the dirt or with a piece of charcoal the shape of the boat on the ground. The boat is about eight big steps long, and three small steps wide. Now fit 13 people inside this space! Do you think that there would have been space for more people?

## boat

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (1925348 KB)

## bow

When a person **bows** down before someone else, they lower their head or the whole top of their body forward. They do this to show respect and humility. A person can also bow down by kneeling in front of a person and putting their head to the ground.

Sometimes people even stretched themselves out flat on the ground in front of a person. This is called falling at someone's feet.

## bow

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (379748 KB)

## burnt offering

In the Old Testament, a **burnt offering** is a form of [sacrifice](#) that people bring to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an [altar](#), which is a special place meant for bringing gifts to God. When a person brings God a burnt offering, they are saying to God: “Just as I am completely burning this animal, I am completely devoted to you.”

## burnt offering

### Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (352172 KB)